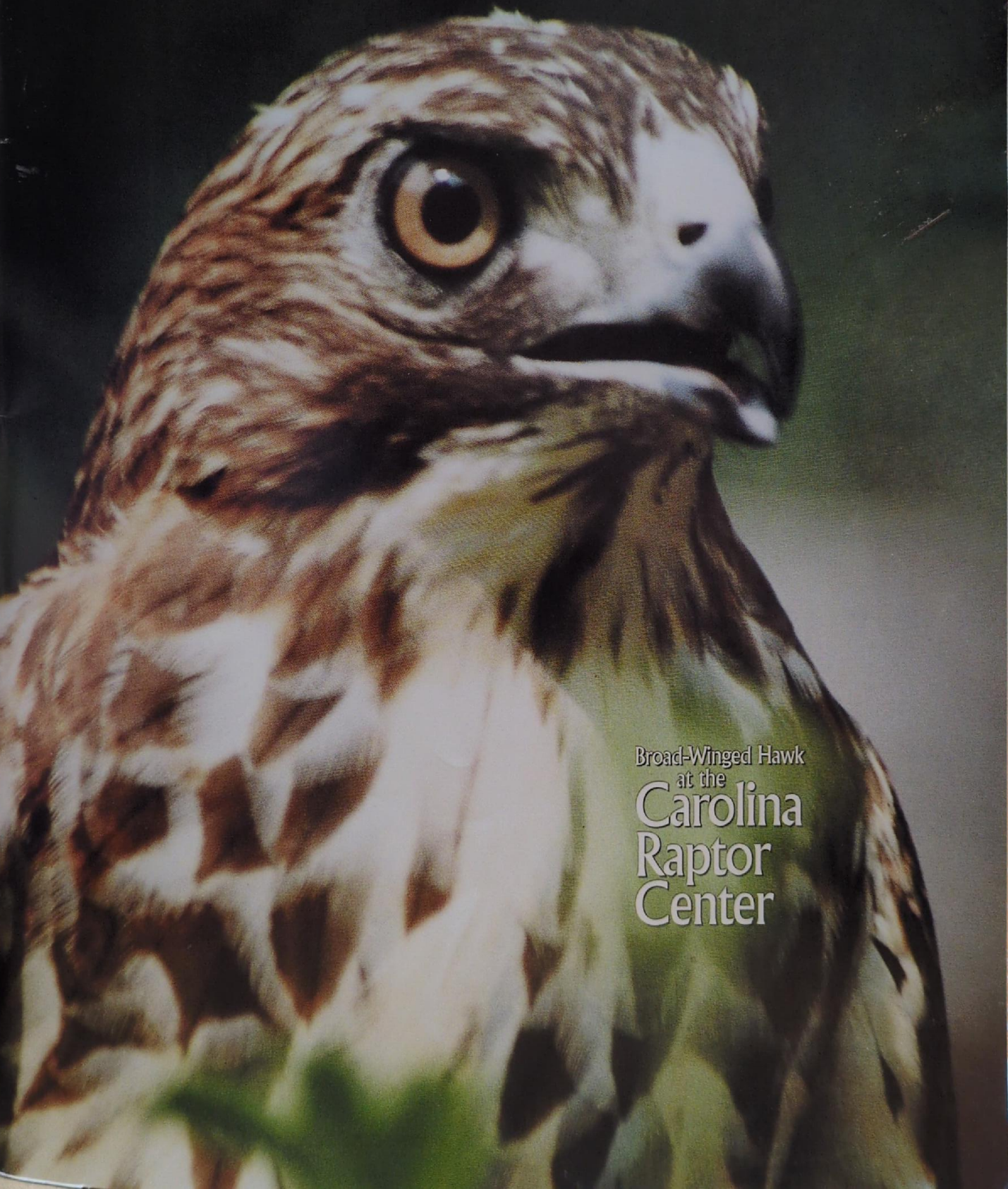


# *The* **CRIER**

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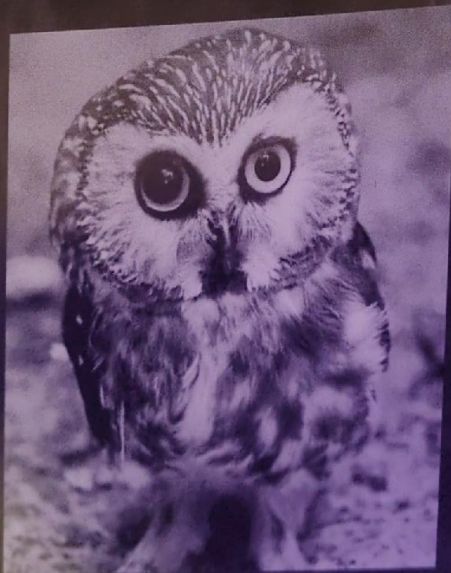


Broad-Winged Hawk  
at the  
**Carolina  
Raptor  
Center**

# Flying High at the Carolina Raptor Center

By Charla Muller  
Photography by Donna Eaton

*Bald Eagle - Nate*



*Northern Saw-Whet Owl - Sage*

## ? *Did you know...*

The round face of the owl directs even the slightest sound to the ears, which are offset for heightened perception. The owl's flexible neck allows the head to turn up to 270 degrees, and the softly tufted feathers allow it to fly while making as much noise as your turning this page.



You've heard of King of the Jungle? Well, at the Carolina Raptor Center you can meet the busboys of the forest. Dedicated to the education and preservation of birds of prey, the Carolina Raptor Center has emerged as a Charlotte jewel and a national resource in the area of endangered species.

Located on 57 acres in Latta Plantation Park, the nationally recognized Raptor Center started nearly 20 years ago as a labor of love.

A biology student at the University of North Carolina at Charlotte volunteered to care for an injured owl. This dedicated endeavor evolved into a fledgling organization in the basement of the university's biology building until 1984 when Mecklenburg County generously offered a 25-year lease on 57 acres within Latta Plantation. The rent - \$1 a year. Two years later, the volunteer-based organization received a three-year decreasing grant from Mecklenburg County to support hired staff.

The next few years provided critical volunteer and monetary support to create a state-of-the-art Nature Trail with permanent cages, to increase supplies and equipment for the rehabilitation program, and to fund the Edna S. Moretti Environmental Education Center (replete with a visitor reception area, an exhibition center, a classroom and administrative office space.) Visitors can also enjoy an outdoor amphitheatre and a "weathering area" for an up close and personal view of the birds. Today, the Carolina Raptor Center is a nationally renowned research and habitat facility dedicated to birds of prey.

The crowning glory at the Carolina Raptor Center in recent years is the new, world-class Eagle Aviary. Marking a two-year fundraising effort, the aviary was completed with a significant contribution from the Betty J. Stanley and J. Stanley Livingstone Foundation. Opened this year, the space provides an expansive, natural residence for up to ten non-releasable golden and bald eagles.

Currently, the Carolina Raptor Center has about 90 "birds in residence" and, at any given time, 75 to 100 of these birds of prey may be housed in the rehabilitation area. This means that any time you visit you can view birds in a natural protective setting while they are mending.

*continued on next page*

### ? Did you know...

The turkey vulture has a wingspan that enables it to soar with a mere one to two beats per second (compare that to 80 beats per second for smaller birds). With one of the most well-developed senses of smell in the bird world, the turkey vulture can find, um, "fragrant" meals that others miss. And the long neck and featherless head make the turkey vulture's job as clean-up detail a breeze.



Red-Tailed Hawk - Skoshi



**Short-Eared Owl – Zuni**



**Broad-Winged Hawk – Shennara**

*continued*

### Education

Rehabilitation, research and education are the cornerstones of the Carolina Raptor Center's mission. Birds take center stage in education. Non-releasable birds (birds that can no longer survive in the wilderness because of permanent injuries) star in presentations and exhibits. And if you've ever attended one, you know their magnificent presence is a real show stopper. The purpose of using live birds of prey as an educational tool is to highlight how habitat destruction, biodiversity, pollution and food webs all impact the way humans, animals and the environment work together.

Since 1981, the Center's education programs have reached over a million people throughout the Southeast – through Center visitors, school programs, civic and social group presentations and visitors to festival and fair exhibits. A successful education component in recent years is the Wild Wings program. This organized education outreach takes programs (with feathered friends as the headline act) to schools and organizations across the Carolinas.

### Rehabilitation

Rehabilitation is the most labor-intensive part of the Center's mission. Some of the birds in the rehabilitation program are orphans. With echoes of the 11 o'clock news, most are injured by human contact – shootings, hit and runs, poisonings and electrocution on high-power electric lines.

The rehabilitation process for birds mirrors that of humans. The birds move from an intensive care hospital to an outdoor aviary and then to a flight cage for exercise and strengthening. If the bird makes a full recovery,

it is released into the wild. If it does not, the bird can permanently check into the Carolina Raptor Center, living in an aviary on the Nature Trail, acting as foster parents to orphans or breeding new birds.

Of the birds that survive the crucial first 24 hours of care, more than half are eventually released back into the wild. To date, the Carolina Raptor Center has treated nearly 6,000 injured birds of prey.

### Research

A critical step to enhancing the long-term viability of birds of prey is research, and the Carolina Raptor Center is one of the leading research groups in the country. Programs include: studying the fall migration habits of hawks; an osprey reintroduction program; a

barn owl distribution study; and an annual mid-winter bald eagle survey.

### Raptor Center Flies with Volunteer Support

A small army of 130 on-site volunteers, full-time and part-time staff members and several interns keep the Carolina Raptor Center alive and running.

Much like the Junior League of Charlotte, volunteers are the lifeblood of the Carolina Raptor Center. They participate in rehabilitating and training the birds for educational programs, maintaining the grounds and buildings, and performing professional services such as bookkeeping, printing and legal work. Transport volunteers deliver rescued raptors to the Center, and veterinarians donate time, services and medication.

What can you do to lend support? Besides volunteer opportunities, you can visit the Raptor Center Tuesday through Saturday, 10 a.m. - 5 p.m. and Sundays, 12 p.m. - 5 p.m. The Center's full-time residents invite you to bring family and friends and learn more about the critical rescue and rehabilitation of birds of prey.

For more information on memberships, the Adopt-A-Bird of Prey program and volunteer opportunities, call 704/875-6521. ☎

### Did you know...

Some vultures don't even need to chew! They are capable of devouring over a pound of meat per minute. Bon appetit....

### Did you know...

The turbo-charged peregrin falcon can achieve speeds up to 200 m.p.h in a "stoop" – a powerful dive for food during which the falcon tilts its head, folds back its wings and does not worry about a speeding ticket.

**SPEED  
LIMIT  
200**

### The Center's Mission

The Carolina Raptor Center is dedicated to environmental education and the conservation of birds of prey through public education, the rehabilitation of injured orphaned raptors, research, and breeding of threatened and endangered species.

### Visiting Hours

Tuesday through Saturday, 10 a.m. - 5 p.m.  
Sunday, 12 p.m. - 5 p.m.